

CORE FORMULA

Point -> one reason -> optional example -> pause or check. -> My view is X. The main reason is Y. [pause] -> Short version: X. The detail is Y if useful. -> I'd do X, mainly because Y. Happy to unpack it if helpful. -> I can't do X. I can do Y. [stop] -> That came out long. Simple version: X.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Make the point once, give one reason, then pause.

BEST FOR

- Workplace updates, meetings and senior conversations
- Dating and social conversation where over-talking kills ease
- Requests, boundaries, refusals and apologies
- Explaining opinions, recommendations or decisions
- Conflict or disagreement where too many words look defensive
- Text messages, emails and follow-ups
- Any moment where you notice yourself talking to reduce your own discomfort

PHRASE BANK

Concise opinions · Stating a view cleanly

- "My view is X, mainly because Y."
- "I'd choose X. The reason is pretty simple: Y."
- "The headline is X. The detail is Y."
- "I think X is the better move."
- "I'm leaning X because it solves the main issue."
- "Honestly, X. That's the whole answer."

Check instead of continuing · Hand over rather than pad

- "Does that answer the question?"
- "Do you want the short version or the full version?"
- "Is that enough detail, or useful to go deeper?"
- "I can unpack that if helpful."
- "I'll pause there."
- "That's the gist - want more?"

Boundaries / saying no · Clean refusals

- "I can't do that, but I can do this."
- "I'm not available for that."
- "That won't work for me."
- "I'm going to say no to that."
- "I don't want to overcommit, so I'll leave it there."
- "No, but thank you for asking."

Work / leadership · Bottom line first

- "Bottom line: I recommend X."
- "The decision I'd make is X."
- "The main risk is Y."
- "The next step is X by Friday."

- "My recommendation is X; the trade-off is Y."
- "Headline first: we're on track. Detail if you want it."

Social / dating · Brevity plus warmth

- "Simple answer: yes."
- "I liked it. Not because it was perfect - because it felt easy."
- "I'll spare you the essay: I'm into it."
- "Short version: I had a good time."
- "I could overanalyse it, but the honest answer is X."
- "Yeah, I'd like to see you again. That simple."

Conflict / disagreement · One concern, not a case

- "The part I disagree with is X."
- "My concern is Y."
- "I see it differently, mainly because X."
- "I don't want to over-argue it. My view is X."
- "I'll say the key point and stop: X."
- "Here's my one concern, then I'll listen."

Digital / text · One-screen replies

- "Quick answer: yes."
- "Short version: I can do Thursday."
- "I'm out this week, but keen another time."
- "Main thought: choose option B."
- "No long explanation - I just don't think that works for me."
- "On it - done by Thursday."

Recovery / reset · Catch and simplify

- "I'm overexplaining. Short version: X."
- "Let me make that cleaner."
- "I'm giving too much detail. The point is X."
- "I'll stop there before I turn this into a TED Talk."
- "Simple version: X. Happy to expand if useful."
- "Ignore the ramble - the point is X."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Uses the technique mechanically or too often, clipping every answer short.
Better: Uses the smallest useful version, then listens.
Best: Uses it only when the cue is present, keeps the wording natural, and adjusts to the response.
2. Weak: Blurts a short answer, then fills the silence with justifications.
Better: Gives the point and one reason, then stops.
Best: Says just enough that the point lands, and lets the pause do the rest.
3. Weak: Talks about being concise instead of just being concise.
Better: Performs one clear behavioural move.
Best: Makes brevity feel like ordinary, confident conversation.

DECISION TREE

If You've made your point and feel the urge to keep talking

Stop. Make the point once, give one reason, then pause.
"My view is X, mainly because Y."

If They look genuinely confused or ask "what do you mean?"

Add one clarifying reason or example - don't just repeat the same words.
"Let me put it another way: the key thing is X."

If They actually ask for your full reasoning

Give the longer version in one clean layer; staying terse here reads as evasive.

"Happy to walk through it - the main factors are..."

If The topic is high-stakes and detail matters for fairness or safety

Prioritise completeness over brevity, and say why you're going long.

"This one needs the full picture, so bear with me."

If Your short answer risks sounding cold

Add one warm line, not five defensive ones.

"Short answer is no - but I'm really glad you asked me."

If You've already landed the point and are now rephrasing it

Stop and hand over with a check instead of another lap.

"Does that answer it, or want me to go deeper?"

SCENARIOS

High-status or senior person

Lead with the answer, then one reason. Rambling doesn't read as respect - it reads as nerves. — "My recommendation is X. The main reason is Y."

Dating or social

Keep answers alive but not over-explained. Brevity plus warmth creates ease. — "I had a really good time. That's the honest version."

Conflict or disagreement

Too much detail sounds defensive. State the concern, pause, and invite their response. — "My one concern is X. What's your read?"

Digital or text

Shorter is usually warmer than a defensive paragraph. Add one human line if needed. — "Can't make Thursday - free most of next week though."

After an awkward moment

Name the over-explaining lightly and reset rather than piling on more words. — "I'm overexplaining - let me simplify."

When detail is genuinely needed

Use layers: give the headline first, then offer the long version. — "Short answer is X. Want the full reasoning?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person is genuinely confused and needs more explanation
- The topic is high stakes and detail is required for safety or fairness
- You are using brevity to avoid accountability
- The other person has asked for your reasoning
- The relationship needs warmth and your short answer could sound cold
- You are trying to seem mysterious rather than clear

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the urge

Through the day, just notice the moments where you keep talking after your point has already landed. Change nothing yet - only count them.

Day 2 — Point plus one reason

In three conversations, answer a question with exactly the point, one reason, then a pause. Nothing after the pause.

Day 3 — Hold the silence

Pick one moment where a pause feels uncomfortable and let it sit for two seconds instead of filling it with words.

Day 4 — Trim a message

Take one text or email before you send it and cut it by 30% while keeping the warmth intact.

Day 5 — One example only

When you explain a view, give a single concrete example, then check "want more detail?" rather than stacking more.

Day 6 — Clean boundary

Say one no or one boundary in a single warm sentence, with no apology-spiral or justification afterwards.

Day 7 — Repair on the fly

Next time you catch yourself over-explaining, name it and reset out loud: "I'm overexplaining - short version is X."

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I answer before explaining?
- Did I give one main reason rather than every reason?
- Did I stop once the point had landed, instead of defending it?
- Did I let a pause sit instead of filling it?
- Did I check before adding more detail?
- Did my brevity still sound warm, not cold?